‘Why don’t you strike with a knife?’ the old shaikh responded bitterly. Akbar, unabashed, demanded an account of the 7000 rupees he had given the shaikh before sending him to Mecca, then put him in prison, under Todar Mal’s charge. It was here, locked up ‘like a defaulting tax-gatherer’ that the erstwhile sadr of Hindustan, the highest judge in all the land, met his end: ‘one night,’ writes Badauni, ‘a mob strangled him, and he went to God.’[12]

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If Akbar’s free hand had only been occupied in swatting his opponents, the story of his life would be far less engaging than it is. It is true enough that Akbar was more than a little autocratic, even megalomaniacal. It required a person of such enlarged ego to straddle the realm and assert his authority as he did – it is Akbar, after all, not Babur, who created the empire that bears his dynasty’s name. But if that is all that he had been, the kind of despot in whom power and ruthless ambition feed upon each other towards no better end than exalting the ruler and enriching his friends, then Akbar might not have survived as much more than one of history’s many Caligulas; madmen with the capacity to exert limitless authority towards the narrowest goals. Even a cursory reading of Akbar’s life, however, reveals a man whose energies extended far beyond self-interest; he was driven towards the accumulation of power and territory, yes, but equally towards the welfare of the increasingly vast population over whom he held sway.

Even Badauni admits, with some disgust, that the ‘common people’ loved their lord, repeating his double-edged slogan, ‘Allah-u-Akbar’, like so many ‘brute beasts’. They had reason for their affection.

More than one of the Jesuits who spent time in Akbar’s court noted the stark contrast in his treatment of nobleman and commoner. ‘To prevent the great nobles becoming insolent through the unchallenged enjoyment of power,’ writes Father Monserrate, Akbar would summon ‘those whom he learns to have become enriched by the revenues of their provinces, and gives them many imperious commands, as though they were his slaves – commands, moreover, obedience to which ill suits their exalted rank and dignity’.[13] Akbar’s amirs were to be kept in check by many means, that is, logistical and psychological. At the same time, the priest notes Akbar’s